Expecting Adam

By Martha Beck

MARTHA: **(Pg 60)** The word mother is more powerful when it is used as a verb than as a noun. There are women who bear and raise children without ever mothering them, and there are people (both male and female) who mother all their lives without ever giving birth. This was one of the greatest gifts I would receive from Adam . . . Against all odds, despite everything that works against it on this unpleasant, uncomfortable planet, mothering is here in abundance.

INTRODUCTION

Growing up with 47 chromosomes is not terribly different from growing up with 46. Children with Down Syndrome read, write, play sports, sing show tunes, and parade around the house in "full pirate regalia" instead of getting ready for school. They have their ups and down; dreams and disappointments; but fundamentally they want what anybody wants — to be valued, respected and accepted for the wonderful people they are.

But for young parents, finding out your child will be born with Down Syndrome is overwhelming.

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JUDY: **(Pg 127-136)** *(Martha and John enter; Martha pushes the blinking light on her answering machine to hear messages) [Beep]* Martha, this is University Health Services. I need to get in touch with you immediately – immediately – regarding the results of the tests. Please get in touch with me as soon as possible.

MARTHA: *(Martha dials the phone)* Hi, Judy. This is Martha Beck. Is there something wrong?

JUDY: We got an unusual reading on your alpha-fetoprotein levels. It was a bit below normal.

MARTHA: Below normal? Well, that's good, isn't it?

JUDY: It's not necessarily bad. But there is a slight statistical correlation between low levels of AFP and Down syndrome.

MARTHA: *(taken aback)* What are my odds?

JUDY: Based on this one test, which is only preliminary, of course – your odds of having a Down's baby are 1 in 895. We want to do the test again to see if we get the same results. Just to be on the safe side. We don't have much time.

MARTHA: Time? Time for what?

JUDY: To terminate. If there's something wrong. *(Martha slowly hangs up the phone and turns to John)*

JOHN: What exactly is the problem.

MARTHA: *(shaking her head in disbelief)* We've got a 1 in 895 shot at a retarded baby.

JOHN: *(smiling and making light of the situation)* I can live with those odds.

MARTHA: *(trying to smile)* I'm . . . I'm a little scared.

JOHN: That's understandable. But even if there's a problem, we've caught it in time. The worst-case scenario is that you might have to have an abortion, and that's a ling shot. Everything's going to be fine.

MARTHA: I might have to have an abortion? I might ***have to have*** an abortion? *(growing angry)* Since when do you decide what I have to do with my body?

JOHN: (surprised) It's just that if the tests show something wrong with the baby, of course we'll abort. We've talked about this.

MARTHA: *(in a low, dangerous voice)* What we've talked about is that I am pro-choice. That means I decide whether or not I'd abort a baby with a birth defect. You steer clear of this one, John-boy. It is not your call! *(beat, while Martha calms herself)* It's just not ethically consistent. I mean, not abortion in general, just this kind of abortion. This designer-baby stuff.

JOHN: *(surprised)* You mean screening for birth defects? What in the world is wrong with it? It's better for everyone.

MARTHA: I'm not so sure of that. But . . . It's not as though we're deciding whether or not to have a baby. We're deciding what kind of baby we're willing to accept. If it's perfect in every way, we keep it. If it doesn't fit the right specifications, whoosh! Out it goes!

JOHN: *(shaking his head)* Don't be silly. You know that isn't true. We're talking about the difference between a healthy, normal baby and a defective one

MARTHA: *(bristles at the word defective)* So what exactly is a 'defective' baby? I mean, I know there are babies born so damaged they can't survive on their own, but what about the ones that would actually live unless they were aborted? Where do you draw the line? What if this baby had a clubfoot or something? Would you tell me I 'had to have' an abortion?

JOHN: Martha, why are you on this soapbox? What's your point?

MARTHA: My point is that I'm trying to get you to tell me what you think constitutes a 'defective' baby. What about . . . oh, I don't know, a hyperactive baby? Or an ugly one?

JOHN: They can't test for those things, and . . .

MARTHA: What if they could? Medicine can do all kinds of magical rick these days. Pretty soon we're going to be aborting babies because they have the gene for alcoholism, or homosexuality, or manic-depression. Did you know that in China they abort a lot of fetuses just because they're female? Is being a girl 'defective' enough for you?

JOHN: I didn't say . . .

MARTHA: *(cutting him off)* Just exactly how smart does a baby have to be before its parents accept it? How good-looking? How healthy? How strong?

JOHN: Honey, this is not eugenics. We aren't talking about breeding a race of supermen. We're talking about taking some of the tragedy out of life. Abortion is a way to deal with the problem, you know? To limit it. That's all I was saying.

MARTHA: And you'd still want me to abort this baby if it wasn't normal. Wouldn't you?

JOHN: Look, the way I see it, if a baby is going to be deformed or something, abortion is a way to keep everyone from suffering – especially that baby. It's like shooting a horse that's broken its leg. A lame horse dies in terrible pain. It can't run anymore, so it can't enjoy life even if it doesn't die. Horses live to run; that's what they do. If a baby is born not being able to do what other people do, I think it's better not to prolong its suffering.

MARTHA: *(softly)* And what is it that people do? (Beat, then to audience) And then I understood . . . The part of us that makes our brief, improbably little lives worth living is the

ability to reach through out own isolation and find strength, and comfort, and warmth for and in each other. This is what human beings do. This is what we live for, the way horses live to run.

******* Break *******

(Pg 181-183) *(the phone rings and Martha answers)*

JUDY: Hello, Martha. It's Judy Trenton from University Health Services. I have some . . . not so good news for you. The results from your amniocentesis are in, and they show that you are carrying a Down syndrome fetus. *(silence)* Martha? Are you there?

MARTHA: *(Softly)* Yeah. *(to audience)* By the time the Down syndrome was diagnosed. I could not more have asked for an abortion than I could have shot [my older daughter] Katie in the head. *(to Judy)* I don't want to terminate the pregnancy. *(she hangs up slowly)*

(Pg 211-212) Those first few days after hearing the diagnosis, I swallowed thousands of appalling bits of information from insensitive and outdated sources. The mustard-yellow book I'd bought at the Co-op was the worst. It had last been updated in 1950, when people with Down syndrome were rarely seen outside of institutions. It makes me sick to think of the thousands of children who were raised in institutions. Isolated, bored and aching with loneliness, many literally turned their faces to the wall and died by the time they were in their teens. The book described this as the normal life course for the human beings it called "mongoloid idiots."

I want to state for the record that putting a person with Down's into an institution is like forcing an otter to live in a Pringle's can. There is nothing wrong with the social adaptability of people like Adam. They thrive on loving interaction. But in the days after Adam's diagnosis, I hadn't learned any of these things. I'd forced myself to accept claims that were both untrue and brutally unkind.:

1. The birth of a Down syndrome child generally destroyed the mother's mental health.
2. The inability of such children to control their bodily functions and their antisocial inclinations.

3. The typical IQ for "mongoloids" – about 35, and by way of comparison, the IQ of a chimpanzee is about 50.

In the days following Adam's diagnosis, I seemed to have no strength at all. I made a half-hearted effort at sleeping, but barely even tried to eat. I was dehydrated and probably needed an IV. But the through of going back to University Health Service was almost unbearable. . . **(Pg 214)** The admitting physician recommended that I spend the night. **(Pg 216)** The next morning I was surprised to see Dr. Grendel approach my bed. *(He takes the chart from the end of the bed are reviews it quickly)*

GRENDEL: (Pg 217) Your chart says that you haven't eaten for four days. *(Gently)* We all know what you're trying to do. There are more efficient ways to take care of this problem than starving yourself until the fetus dies.

MARTHA: *(shocked)* Excuse me?

GRENDEL: Martha, listen to me. I have been in this business for a very long time. You realize that you are placing a very heavy burden on yourself and your entire family. Did you know that 80% of couples who have a child with this condition end up divorcing? I would not make the choice that you have made. I have never known anyone who would.

VOICE IN MARTHA'S HEAD: (Pg 238) *(From the books she's been reading)* It is the duty of every woman to screen her pregnancies and eliminate fetuses that would be a detriment to society.

MARTHA: (Pg 220) *(to audience)* Dr. Grendel, who had never seen a woman elect to keep a Down syndrome baby, was ignorant when it came to the actual consequences of my choice. *(to Grendel)* **(Pg 222-223)** Thank you. You can go now. As Grendel stared at me in frustration and disbelief, Adam gave me a cheerful wallop just below the navel. Briefly, for the first time since I had bought the mustard-yellow book and started soaking in the prejudices against the developmentally disabled world, I was not afraid at all.

*****Break*****

MARTHA: Today, [Adam is nine] and **(Pg 317)** living with Adam, loving Adam has taught me a lot about the truth. He has taught me to look at things in themselves, not at the value a

brutal and often senseless word assigns to them. As Adam's mother I have been able to see quite clearly that he is no less beautiful for being called ugly, no less wise for appearing dull, no less precious for being seen as worthless. And neither am I. Neither are you. Neither is any of us.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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